

How Election Workers Make Sure Votes Are Counted Right

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The **midterm elections** end on Election Day in November, but people in many states are already voting. Election workers started getting ready even earlier.

In Davis County, Utah, workers put practice **ballots** through the counting machines before any real **ballots** are counted. Some practice **ballots** are filled out wrong on purpose. This test checks that the machines count correctly and catch mistakes, like a voter picking too many **candidates**.

Most people in Utah vote by mail. **County clerk** Brian McKenzie explained that every envelope has its own bar code, so no one can get more than one ballot. Two workers pick up returned **ballots**, and cameras watch them all day and night. Workers check each voter's signature, and **ballots** are counted again at every step. McKenzie said nothing is connected to the internet.

This year, there was a fight in Washington over voting by mail. The Supreme Court blocked new mail ballot rules last month. McKenzie said sudden changes close to an election can confuse voters.

Word Treasure

midterm elections -- Elections held in the middle of a president's four-year term.

ballots -- The papers or forms people use to vote.

candidates -- People who are trying to get elected.

County clerk -- A local official who helps run elections.

Background you need

In the United States, local officials in each county run elections and count the votes. Before Election Day, workers test the counting machines and check mail ballots carefully so every vote counts only once.

Break it down

WHO: Election workers and county clerk Brian McKenzie

WHAT: Testing counting machines and carefully checking mail ballots

WHERE: Davis County, Utah

WHY: To make sure every vote is counted correctly before the midterm elections

Why it matters

Knowing how votes are checked helps kids understand how their families' choices are counted fairly in elections.

Test what you remember

1. When does the midterm election end?

- ☐ (A) Next summer
- ☐ (B) In January
- ☐ (C) It already ended
- ☐ (D) On Election Day in November

2. Why are some practice ballots filled out wrong on purpose?

- ☐ (A) To trick voters
- ☐ (B) By accident
- ☐ (C) To check that machines catch mistakes
- ☐ (D) To save time

3. Where do the election workers in the story work?

- ☐ (A) New York City
- ☐ (B) Paris
- ☐ (C) Houston
- ☐ (D) Davis County, Utah

4. How do most people in Utah vote?

- ☐ (A) By mail
- ☐ (B) By phone
- ☐ (C) Only in person
- ☐ (D) Online

5. What does each envelope have so no one gets two ballots?

- ☐ (A) A photo
- ☐ (B) Its own bar code
- ☐ (C) A sticker
- ☐ (D) A stamp of a flag

6. What did the Supreme Court block last month?

- ☐ (A) New mail ballot rules
- ☐ (B) Election Day
- ☐ (C) Signature checks
- ☐ (D) Voting machines

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: D 4: A 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

1. County clerk Brian McKenzie: Says sudden changes close to an election can confuse voters.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):